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Eight smart ways to get a pay raise

By **NORMAN LIEBERMAN**

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First, let's dispel a myth: You don't deserve a raise simply for living and breathing the same duties an extra year. If your company has had a profitable year, and you've been performing your job well, your boss should consider giving you a raise. But how large that raise should be depends on the added value you've brought to your job. Did you take on additional duties, bring in revenue, save the firm money, or accomplish other goals since your last review?

It's your responsibility to make it clear why you deserve a raise. Your boss doesn't know or remember all you do each week, especially if you're the quiet type, working diligently behind the scenes. A boss is supposed to know the bigger picture, such as how your duties fit into the department or company, not the details.

Keep a private list of your accomplishments and additional responsibilities, including any work problems you've solved. Your list should be specific and your accomplishments measurable. Instead of saying, "I do all the Accounts Receivable processing," say, "I reduced the AR backlog by 42 percent in three months."

Ask your boss how you can be of additional help. At the same time you'll be expanding your career knowledge. Don't ask for more money at this point! You're not worth it until you learn the new work and can demonstrate your effectiveness. Then you'll have real job security - you'll know and do too much for the company to want to lose you.

Offer to help others in the office with their work, especially those who can teach you new methods or procedures. Be a good neighbor and become more valuable at the same time. Employees who go above and beyond typically get rewarded either at their present job or at future ones.

Generally speaking, you will have more latitude in negotiating salaries in smaller, less bureaucratic firms. Larger companies are often more rigid. But even in larger firms you can try to get your position re-classified to a higher pay grade if you take on more responsibility to support such a move.

Surprise is critical. Don't tell anyone associated with your company - even your best friend - that you're going to ask for a raise. Your best friend has other office friends, and before you know it, your boss is ready for you. Suddenly he or she is complaining about your work, and you're too intimidated to ask for a raise.

Never cite personal reasons for seeking a raise. Your commute may be too long, and everyone else with the same position may make more money than you do. But these have nothing to do with the value you bring to your job. Your boss will respect you more if you ask for a raise based on your merits, not on your personal needs.

Whatever you do, don't threaten to leave unless you get a raise. While your boss might give you an increase, this tactic could put your job in jeopardy. Unhappy about being pressured into paying you more than he or she thinks you deserve and feeling potential pressure from others who will think this is a great strategy, your boss could soon be looking to replace you with someone who costs less and isn't a troublemaker.

LOOKING ELSEWHERE

Often, nothing seems to work in getting a raise at your current job. When this occurs, it may be necessary to move out in order to move up. Your boss and co-workers shouldn't know of your intentions to look elsewhere. In fact, this is the time to put in extra effort at work so as to not draw negative attention to yourself. Your boss will remember your positive attitude when it comes to giving you a reference later.

Before looking elsewhere, **make sure you have a realistic understanding of the salary range for the work you are seeking.** There are many places to find this information. The reference librarians at most public libraries can tell you where to find appropriate salary surveys for your industry and job title. Another source to check is with your industry's professional

associations. For example, if you are a civil engineer, you can call the associations that represent civil engineers and inquire about their salary surveys.

If you find a job you like, but the pay is less than you feel is adequate, **ask the employer to work out with you some potential performance objectives.** Let's say one would be to get the past-due accounts receivables brought down 15 percent within six months, along with any other performance goals you've both determined to be reasonable and acceptable. When these measurable goals are reached, you automatically receive a predetermined increase. The goals and the agreed-upon increase should be written out, and signed and dated by you and your potential new boss on company letterhead. If this employer doesn't agree to write out the goals, then it is time to move on to another interview.

WORD OF WARNING

Finally, never use a new job offer as a springboard to getting a pay raise in your current position. Say you've found a new job, given notice, and your boss counteroffers with a raise that meets or exceeds the salary offer from your new employer. Should you accept this offer? No! If your boss didn't think you deserved more money before you gave notice, why are you suddenly worth more money after you've given notice? In this case, your boss is "rewarding" you out of a sense of panic, not based on merit and the value you bring to the job. You might keep your current job, and get the pay raise you were looking for, but it may only be a matter of time before your boss replaces you with a "cheaper" model.

Remember, preparation is the key to securing more money. Be ready with a list of your accomplishments and the extra responsibilities you've taken on. In this way, you won't feel like you're begging for more pay, and your boss won't feel compelled to take care of you or risk losing you. Why? Because you've demonstrated that you've earned the raise.

Try to answer the 10 questions below about securing a pay raise. As you do so, ask yourself whether you know the complete answer, or just part of it. The answers to these questions are contained in the story:

1. What should you never tell your boss when you're seeking a raise?
2. What should you never consider after you've given notice that you're quitting?
3. Should your boss know most of the daily details regarding your work?
4. If a co-worker with the same responsibilities is paid more than you, should you bring this up when asking for a raise?
5. Should you tell your best friend at work about your intention to seek a pay raise? Why or why not?
6. When is a particularly good time to work your hardest and present the best attitude?
7. Is a long commute and its added cost a good reason to ask for more money?
8. Are you more likely to get a raise in a large firm or a small one?
9. Do you know how best to list and describe your accomplishments when seeking a raise?
10. If your boss gives you a lot more responsibility, should you immediately ask for a raise?

If you missed one question, congratulations! You have an excellent handle on how to get a pay raise, and chances are high that you will secure one for yourself. Caution: Don't get overly enthusiastic about your abilities. There are numerous subtleties to getting a pay raise. Often missing one of the small details can cost you money.

If you missed two questions, you did very well. You have an above-average understanding of the pay-raise process.

If you missed three or more questions, you could use guidance to maximize your chances for a healthy pay raise. Because asking for a raise, like seeking a new job, is something you probably don't do frequently, chances are that your skills are not honed. Make sure you prepare yourself well before venturing forward, because the money you leave on the table is yours.

- NORMAN LIEBERMAN

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